Lesson 27: Pronunciation: Review of Consonants and -S Endings; Content Words

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 3: Zero Waste

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 3.3 Review - Voiced and Unvoiced Consonants and -S Endings; 3.4 Content Words.

In this lesson

First you will review two rules from Unit 2 with the new zero waste words: voiced and unvoiced final sounds, and -s endings. Then you will learn the difference between content words and function words. You will practise the rhythm of English with two nursery rhymes and a paragraph from Lauren's video.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Decide if the final sound of a word is voiced or unvoiced.
- Say -s endings correctly as /s/ or /z/.
- Find the content words and the function words in a sentence.
- Stress content words and say function words quickly and softly.
- Read a nursery rhyme and a short paragraph with English rhythm.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
final sound	the last sound you say (not the last letter)	"waste" ends with /t/; the e is silent.
voiced	your throat vibrates (buzzes) when you say the sound	the /m/ at the end of "foam"
unvoiced	no vibration; only air	the /k/ at the end of "chopstick"
-s ending	the s on plural nouns and on verbs after he, she, it	recipes, makes
content word	a word that gives the most important information; usually stressed	bank in "Dad's at the bank."
function word	a small word that makes the sentence grammatically correct; usually not stressed	at, the in "Dad's at the bank."
stress	saying a syllable or word stronger, longer and higher in pitch	TWIN·kle
rhythm	the beat of speech: strong and weak words	Twinkle, twinkle, little star
nursery rhyme	a short traditional poem or song for children	The incy wincy spider

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
negative auxiliary	a helping verb with "not"; it is a content word	can't, isn't, don't

Rules and explanations

Voiced and unvoiced final sounds (review)

- Put your hand on your throat. If you feel a vibration on the final sound, it is **voiced**. If you feel no vibration, it is **unvoiced**.
- Listen to the final **sound**, not the final letter. "Waste" ends with the sound /t/. "Recipe" ends with a vowel sound.
- Vowel sounds are always voiced.

-S endings (review)

Say	When	Examples
/s/	after an unvoiced final sound such as /f/, /k/, /p/, /t/, /θ/ (as in "think")	look - looks, help - helps, wait - waits
/z/	after a voiced final sound such as /b/, /d/, /g/, /l/, /m/, /n/, /r/, /v/, /ð/ (as in "mother"), and after vowels	roam - roams, need - needs, enjoy - enjoys
/əz/ (extra syllable)	after /s/, /z/, /ʃ/ (as in "push"), /ʧ/ (as in "watch"), /ʤ/ (as in "judge")	push - pushes, watch - watches, judge - judges

Content words and function words

- **Content words** give the most important information. They are usually **stressed** and **higher** in pitch.
- **Function words** make your sentences grammatically correct. They are usually **not stressed** and **lower** in pitch.

Content words	Examples	Function words	Examples
nouns	friend, Bob, work	articles	a, an, the
verbs	eat, play, run	prepositions	of, to, for, with
adjectives	beautiful, good, angry	pronouns	he, she, I, you
adverbs	always, cheerfully, easily	auxiliaries	can, have, is
interjections	Wow! Oops!	conjunctions	but, or, so
wh- words	why, where, what		
negative auxiliaries	can't, isn't, don't		

Rhythm

- English has a beat. The stressed syllables of content words come on the beat. The function words between them are short and weak.
- It is easiest to hear this rhythm in songs and nursery rhymes. Clap on the beat.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no /v/ sound, so /v/ can become /f/. "Alternative" ends with voiced /v/, so "alternatives" ends with /z/, not /s/. - Many Arabic speakers say small words like "to", "the" and "of" with a full, clear vowel. In English, function words are usually weak and quick.

Practice

1. Voiced or unvoiced? Say each word with your hand on your throat. Is the final sound voiced or unvoiced? Write the words in two columns: Unvoiced / Voiced. toothpaste, recipe, alternative, cinnamon, chopstick, combine, tablespoon, coconut, liquid, foam, fluctuate, waste

2. -S endings. Does the final sound of each word have an /s/ sound or a /z/ sound? Write the words in two columns, /s/ and /z/. Example: recipes - /z/. Then say all the words aloud. recipes, makes, alternatives, chopsticks, combines, tablespoons, takes, benefits, coconuts, liquids, oils, foams, fluctuates, wastes, stirs, forks, ingredients

3. Video: Content Words (Rachel's English). Watch the video (see Watch online). Then answer.

a. What are the four types of content words she mentions?

b. Choose the correct word.

1. Content words give the _____ in a sentence. (information / grammar)
2. Function words give the _____ in a sentence. (information / grammar)
3. Content words are _____. (stressed / not stressed)
4. Content words are _____ in pitch. (higher / lower)
5. Function words are _____. (stressed / not stressed)
6. Function words are _____ in pitch. (higher / lower)

c. Find the content words in these sentences. Say them aloud.

1. Dad's at the bank.
2. She went to the store.
3. He'll be here soon.
4. She took the red car.
5. Sometimes it's hard to walk in a single woman's shoes.
6. Bob and I finally received our wedding gift from Michael.

4. More examples. Add one more example of each type of content word and function word in the tables in Rules and explanations. Check your ideas with your tutor.

5. Video: Stress and Rhythm in English (Elemental English). Watch it to review (see Watch online).

6. Nursery rhymes. Read the two rhymes in your lesson material ("Twinkle, twinkle, little star" and "The incy wincy spider").

- a. Clap your hands to the beat. Which words land on the beat? Which words are emphasized? Underline them.
- b. Which words are weak and less easy to hear? Write some examples.
- c. Is the entire content word stressed, or just one syllable? Circle the stressed syllable in each content word.
- d. Practise both rhymes. Then record yourself with your phone and listen back.

7. Read and record. Circle the content words. Practise reading the sentences aloud. Then record yourself and listen back.

1. Toothpaste usually foams up in your mouth when you brush your teeth.
2. When you upcycle something, that means you find a new way to use it instead of throwing it in the trash.
3. If you lead a zero waste lifestyle, that means you don't make any trash.
4. Lauren said the consistency of the toothpaste can fluctuate a lot. When it's cold, the toothpaste gets hard and when it's hot, the toothpaste can become liquid.
5. Peppermint and cinnamon are two examples of flavors you can put in your toothpaste.
6. I use baking soda in cookie and cake recipes, but you can also use it in your toothpaste recipe.

8. Lauren's paragraph. Use the paragraph "Zero Waste Toothpaste" in your lesson material (it begins "Hey everybody, this is Lauren from Trash is for Tossers").

- a. Circle all the content words.
- b. Listen to the first 23 seconds of the video (see Watch online). Listen for the words that are stressed and higher in pitch. Did Lauren emphasize the words you circled? Are there any exceptions? Why?
- c. Practise reading the paragraph. Stress the content words and reduce the function words. Record yourself and listen back.

Speak with your tutor

- "Say a word from Unit 3, like 'foam' or 'waste'. I will say if the final sound is voiced or unvoiced, and then say the -s form. Correct me."
- "Ask me about my friend's daily routine. I will answer with he or she verbs. Listen to my -s endings and correct them."
- "Give me five short sentences about zero waste. For each one, I will say the content words. Tell me if I am right."
- "Let me read Lauren's paragraph aloud. Then tell me which words I should stress more."

Read aloud

- foam - foams /z/; waste - wastes /s/
- recipe - recipes /z/; chopstick - chopsticks /s/
- TWIN·kle, TWIN·kle, LIT·tle STAR.
- DAD'S at the BANK.
- She WENT to the STORE.
- I ab·so·LUTE·ly LOVE this REC·i·pe.
- It's a GREAT al·TER·na·tive to BUY·ing TOOTH·paste.
- PEP·per·mint and CIN·na·mon are TWO ex·AM·ples of FLA·vors.

Watch online

- Content Words (Rachel's English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QPbNhsCkj7k
- Stress and Rhythm in English: A Quick Overview (Elemental English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yr1vRim40HM
- Zero Waste Toothpaste (listen to the first 23 seconds): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DIpTXQl7qTo

Answer key

1. (book) Unvoiced: toothpaste, chopstick, coconut, fluctuate, waste. Voiced: recipe, alternative, cinnamon, combine, tablespoon, liquid, foam. (The unvoiced words end with /t/ or /k/. "Recipe" ends with a vowel sound, so it is voiced.)

2. (book) /s/: makes, chopsticks, takes, benefits, coconuts, fluctuates, wastes, forks, ingredients. /z/: recipes, alternatives, combines, tablespoons, liquids, oils, foams, stirs. (Every /s/ word has /k/ or /t/ before the s.)

3. a. Nouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs (check this with the video). b. 1 information, 2 grammar, 3 stressed, 4 higher, 5 not stressed, 6 lower. c. 1 Dad, bank; 2 went, store; 3 here, soon; 4 took, red, car; 5 Sometimes, hard, walk, single, woman's, shoes; 6 Bob, finally, received, wedding, gift, Michael. ("Be" in sentence 3 is usually not stressed, like "is".)

4. (example answer) nouns: book; verbs: write; adjectives: happy; adverbs: quickly; interjections: Ouch!; wh- words: when; negative auxiliaries: won't. Articles: none (a, an and the are the only articles); prepositions: in; pronouns: they; auxiliaries: will; conjunctions: and.

6. a. Twinkle: four beats in each line. Line 1: TWIN-, TWIN-, LIT-, STAR. Line 2: HOW, WON-, WHAT, ARE. Line 3: UP, -BOVE, WORLD, HIGH. Line 4: LIKE, DIA-, IN, SKY. The beats fall on the content words. The song also puts a beat on a few small words (are, up, above, like, in) to keep the rhythm. Incy wincy: the content words are emphasized (incy, wincy, spider, climbed, water, spout, down, came, rain, washed, out, sun, dried, again). b. Weak words: I, you, a, the, so, and. c. Only one syllable: TWIN·kle, LIT·tle, WON·der, DIA·mond, SPI·der, WA·ter, a·GAIN, IN·cy, WIN·cy (check). One-syllable content words (star, world, sky, rain, sun, spout) are stressed as a whole word.

7. Content words: 1 Toothpaste, usually, foams up, mouth, brush, teeth. 2 upcycle, means, find, new, way, use, instead, throwing, trash. 3 lead, zero, waste, lifestyle, means, don't, make, trash. 4 Lauren, said, consistency, toothpaste, fluctuate, lot, cold, toothpaste, gets, hard, hot, toothpaste, become, liquid. 5 Peppermint, cinnamon, two, examples, flavors, put, toothpaste. 6 use, baking soda, cookie, cake, recipes, also, use, toothpaste, recipe. ("When" and "if" join two parts of a sentence here, so they are usually not stressed. Numbers like "two" give information, so they are stressed.)

8. a. (example answer) Hey, everybody, Lauren, Trash, Tossers, today, show, make, Zero Waste Toothpaste / absolutely, love, recipe / great, alternative, buying, toothpaste, tubes, difficult, impossible, recycle / also, works, extremely, well / using, years, still, have, almost, teeth. b. (example answer) Listen and decide. A speaker can give extra stress to a word to show strong feeling, and may not stress every content word when speaking fast.

My notes